The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Donald Trump delayed signing an **executive order** that reportedly would have given his government more oversight of new **AI models**. He said he "didn't like certain aspects" of the order and that it "gets in the way" of America's tech race against China. Several top AI bosses were apparently unable to attend the planned signing on Thursday, sending other executives instead.

Ozgur Ozel, the leader of **Turkey's** opposition party, was ousted after a court annulled the results of a Republican People's Party congress in 2023, which it ruled were irregular. Kemal Kilicdaroglu, a divisive politician who previously lost to Recep Tayyip Erdogan, the country's strongman, will be reinstated as interim leader of the party. The decision will likely strengthen Mr Erdogan's grip on the country.

Marco Rubio, **America's** secretary of state, said there was "some progress" in talks with **Iran**, but added that he was not "overly optimistic". Pakistani mediators were expected to travel to Tehran on Thursday. Meanwhile, Mr Trump said America would obtain and "probably destroy" Iran's highly-enriched uranium. According to *Reuters* Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader, issued a directive against sending its uranium stocks abroad.

Manufacturing activity in America rose to a four-year high this month. The S&P factory purchasing managers' index, a monthly industry survey, rose 0.8 points to 55.3 in May (a figure over 50 indicates expansion). The data suggest companies are building inventories in case the Gulf war disrupts supply chains. Activity in the service sector remained flat.

A court in Paris found **Air France**, an airline carrier, and **Airbus**, a planemaker, guilty of manslaughter for the crash of flight AF447 in 2009. The plane stalled during a thunderstorm over the Atlantic Ocean, killing all 228 people on board. The ruling overturns a 2023 acquittal. Both companies must each pay a fine of €225,000 ($261,000); they are expected to appeal.

Walmart, the world's biggest retailer, published worse-than-expected projections for the year ahead as high fuel costs driven by the war in Iran hit consumer spending. The company's finance chief warned that if costs stay elevated, shoppers will see prices rise. Its annual net sales growth target remained at 4.5% (from 3.5%). Investors had hoped for more; Walmart's shares fell by around 7%.

Itamar Ben-Gvir, Israel's national-security minister, posted a video of himself taunting handcuffed activists who were aboard an aid flotilla bound for Gaza on social media. The clip sparked outrage at home and abroad. Binyamin Netanyahu, the prime minister, said the behaviour was "not in line with Israel's values". Britain and France said they would summon Israel's ambassadors.

Figure of the day: 20%, the probable share of mothers who struggle to breastfeed. Yet the problem remains badly under-researched.

Photograph: Getty Images

The art of not making a deal

On Wednesday Donald Trump said he was in "no hurry" to reach an agreement that ends his war in Iran. Make of that what you will. The day before America's president said that Iran had just "two or three days" to cut a deal before he started bombing the country again. On Monday he threatened strikes before pulling back, claiming that Gulf states had begged him to hold fire.

The war seems stuck in a loop: Mr Trump makes a threat, backs down, and then insists vague progress has been made in negotiations. He has faced the same diplomatic dilemma for weeks. Iran is willing to make a preliminary deal that reopens the Strait of Hormuz. But to avoid embarrassment, America is seeking more concessions on Iran's nuclear programme than Iran has so far been willing to give. Negotiators are trying to split the difference. Iran could make some fuzzy commitments, with the details to be worked out later. But as the impasse drags on, the threat of renewed fighting grows.

Photograph: Reuters

SpaceX reaches for the stars

Elon Musk's SpaceX filed for an IPO this week, targeting a public listing in June. Before Mr Musk potentially becomes a trillionaire, however, the company is due to conduct another test of its giant Starship rocket on Thursday. It will be the first flight of Starship "version 3", a redesigned rocket that incorporates lessons from its predecessors' failures.

Starship's performance will determine SpaceX's future. It is the only machine capable of transporting a new generation of bigger satellites designed to provide more capacity to SpaceX's fast-growing Starlink internet service. And only it will be able to launch the space-going data-centres that Mr Musk believes will ultimately allow artificial-intelligence labs to avoid Earthly constraints of limited power generation and public opposition. Starship was meant to be operational already, but previous models have had trouble with the heat shield that protects the rocket's second stage as it returns to Earth. Mr Musk will be hoping that the stars align this time around.

Photograph: Getty Images

Another gloomy outlook for Europe

The European economy was just gathering steam after years of mediocre growth when Donald Trump attacked Iran. Since then economic sentiment has dived, growth forecasts have been slashed (again), and the European Central Bank has begun pondering interest-rate increases to contain inflation. Data released on Thursday has not improved this trajectory. The European Commission cut its economic growth forecast for this year from 1.4% to 1.1%. Meanwhile the eurozone purchasing-managers' index for May fell to 47.5 from 48.8 in April, its lowest reading since 2023.

If Britain is any guide, the continent's consumers won't be any more optimistic than in April. This week the country reported the weakest household sentiment in almost three years. Petrol prices are still high; job uncertainty has risen. Businesses may have adjusted to high prices, but fear what awaits them once oil supplies run out. The EU's economic commissioner reckons that even the reduced growth estimate could be halved if conflict in the Gulf drags on.

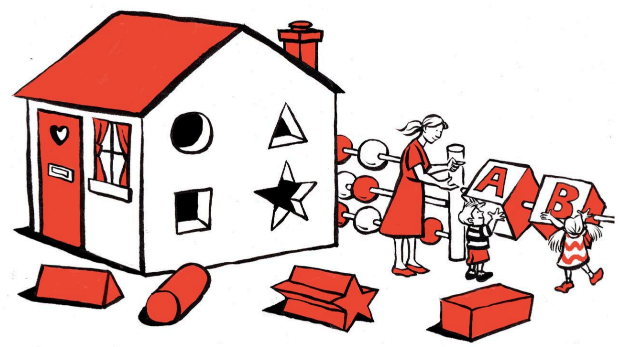


Illustration: David Simonds

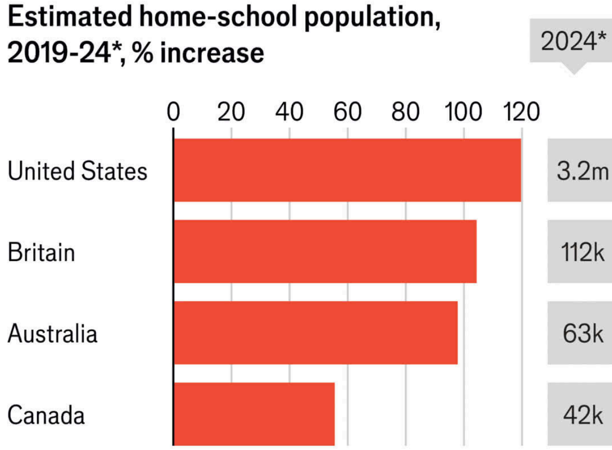
The home-school boom

Home-schooling has long been seen as a fringe phenomenon associated with fanatical parents, socially inept children and patchy pedagogy. But it is moving into the mainstream across the world. In America 6% of the school-age population were home-educated in 2024—double the share in 2019. In Britain and Australia the number of home-schooled children has roughly doubled over the same period. Organisers of the world's biggest home-schooling convention, which begins in Kissimmee, Florida on Thursday, expect many of the 18,000 attendees to come from abroad.

Participants may be diverse in other respects. In America home-schoolers are still associated with white Christians, but growth is rising among families of colour. According to Census Bureau data, a higher percentage of homeschool parents identify as LGBT than do public or private school parents. Globally parents increasingly say that their main reason for home-schooling is to ensure their child's physical or psychological safety. For a growing number, there's no place like home-school.

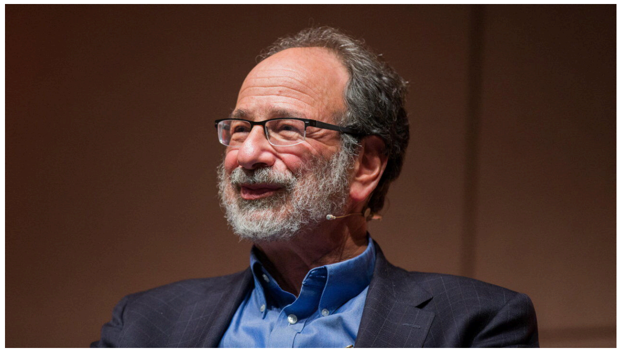
A new school of thought

Estimated home-school population, 2019-24*, % increase



*Or latest available

Sources: "Reasons why parents home school in Australia", by R. Couper and T. Harding, *Issues in Educational Research*, 2024; ADCS; national statistics



Photograph: Alamy

Alvin Roth investigates repugnant markets

Would you like to buy a kidney? How about heroin? Or sex? Don’t worry: you haven’t wandered down the wrong alley—these and other morally questionable transactions are the subject of a new book by Alvin Roth, a Nobel-prize winning economist. Published in Britain on Thursday, “Moral Economics” looks at the murky world of “repugnant transactions”: deals in which buyers and sellers happily transact, but which onlookers would rather ban on moral grounds.

For Mr Roth, moral economics is about trade-offs. Are the harms of allowing an activity greater than those of disallowing it? Policy, he argues, should weigh both. Two principles emerge. First, bans never fully work: motivated buyers and sellers find workarounds. Second, prohibition generally reduces the size of the market; it would be cheaper and easier to buy heroin if it was legal. It might also be safer. That leaves Mr Roth asking whether the restrictions or the market cause more harm. Here, too, the answer is that it depends.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Pomeranian, Havanese and Sheltie are breeds of which animal?

Wednesday: Which famous American landmark had the letters "land" removed in 1949?

True peace is not merely the absence of war, it is the presence of justice.

Jane Addams